

The California Berry Growing Cheat Sheet

Berries reward patience. Most are shallow-rooted, long-lived, and forgiving once they settle into the right spot. This one-page guide gives you the essentials for the five berries that do best in coastal California, so you can plant with confidence and skip the common first-year mistakes.

Which berry for your space?

- **Small space or containers:** strawberries, blueberries (in acidic potting mix), thornless blackberries in a half barrel.
- **Fences and trellises:** blackberries and raspberries, which both need support.
- **Full sun, room to spread:** mulberry (a full tree) and raspberry rows.
- **Coastal fog belt:** strawberries and blackberries thrive here. For blueberries, choose low-chill southern highbush varieties.

Sun, soil, and spacing at a glance

Berry	Sun	Soil pH	Spacing
Strawberry	Full sun	5.5 to 6.8	12 to 18 in
Blackberry	Full sun	5.5 to 7.0	3 to 4 ft
Raspberry	Full sun*	5.5 to 6.5	2 to 3 ft
Blueberry	Full sun	4.5 to 5.5	4 to 5 ft
Mulberry	Full sun	5.5 to 7.0	15+ ft

*Afternoon shade helps raspberries in hot inland spots. Blueberries need acidic soil, so amend with peat or sulfur before planting.

Pruning quick rules

- **Strawberries:** remove runners unless propagating, and renew beds every three years.
- **Black and raspberries:** most fruit forms on second-year canes, so cut spent canes to the ground after harvest.
- **Blueberries:** prune lightly in years one through three, then remove the oldest canes.
- **Mulberry:** prune only when dormant, since it bleeds sap if cut in spring.

Watering

- Berries are shallow-rooted, so steady, consistent moisture beats deep and infrequent watering.
- Mulch heavily to hold that moisture and keep roots cool.
- For blueberries, use rainwater or non-alkaline water, because tap water slowly raises the soil pH over time.

Coastal-California harvest windows

- **Strawberries:** late spring through fall, for everbearing types.
- **Blackberries and raspberries:** summer, with some fall-bearing varieties.
- **Blueberries:** late spring into summer.
- **Mulberry:** late spring to early summer.

Top three beginner mistakes

1. Planting blueberries in regular garden soil. They need acidic soil, so amend with peat or sulfur.
2. Letting brambles grow unsupported and untrimmed, which leads to a thorny tangle and a poor harvest.
3. Letting the water swing during fruiting, which gives you small, seedy, deformed berries.

Want the full picture for each berry?

Every berry above has a complete growth-stage guide, from first leaf to ripe fruit, at

ambitiousharvest.com/learn